

Comprehensive Research Report on Great Tartary

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Executive Summary

This report provides a comprehensive synthesis and critical analysis of the historical and cartographic entity known as “Great Tartary.” The research objective is to compile findings from extensive reviews of cartographic records, historical accounts of governance and trade, and specific geopolitical events, such as the 1812 Fire of Moscow, to construct a holistic understanding of Tartary. The report meticulously examines the evolution of Tartary as a term on European maps from the 13th to the 19th centuries, tracing its origins as a vague exonym for a vast, poorly understood region of Asia to its eventual disappearance [1, 9]. This cartographic transformation is analyzed in the context of the actual political and economic realities of the diverse peoples who inhabited these lands, primarily organized into various khanates and engaged in extensive trade networks like the Silk and Fur Roads [74, 78, 79].

The key findings of this report establish that “Tartary” was a European cartographic convention, a “cognitive placeholder” for the complex mosaic of Mongol and Turkic peoples of the Eurasian Steppe [1]. Its depiction on maps evolved from a single, semi-mythical landmass, reflecting the legacy of the Mongol Empire, to a subdivided territory (e.g., Muscovite, Chinese, and Independent Tartary) as European geographical knowledge improved [1, 9]. The term’s ultimate disappearance was not the result of a conspiratorial erasure but a natural and logical consequence of imperial expansion, particularly by the Russian Empire, which consolidated and administratively defined these territories under new names like “Siberia” [1, 9, 24]. The advancement of scientific geography and rigorous surveying during the Enlightenment and the 19th century rendered the ambiguous term obsolete [9].

Furthermore, this report critically evaluates the modern alternative theory of a lost, technologically advanced “Tartarian Empire” [10]. It deconstructs claims related to systematic historical erasure, a cataclysmic “mud flood,” the anomalous nature of the 1812 Moscow fire, the use of circular geological formations as evidence of advanced technology, and the revisionist theory regarding the origin of the Great Wall of China [32, 37, 49, 85]. The analysis concludes that these claims are unsupported by the historical, archaeological, and geological record [10, 90, 92]. The evidence overwhelmingly indicates that the “Tartarian Empire” theory is a modern myth constructed through the misinterpretation of cartographic conventions, architectural styles, and natural phenomena [11, 86]. The report distinguishes between what is historically verifiable about the region labeled Tartary and what is purely speculative, concluding that while the history of the peoples of Inner Asia is rich and complex, it bears no resemblance to the narrative of a suppressed global superpower.

Synthesis of Research Findings

The entity known as “Great Tartary” is best understood not as a singular empire but as a complex intersection of European cartographic practice, the historical reality of diverse Eurasian peoples, and the geopolitical dynamics of expanding empires. A synthesis of the available research reveals a narrative of evolving knowledge, where a vague geographical label was gradually replaced by precise political and administrative designations. This process was driven by exploration, conquest, and the scientific standardization of geography, which together filled in the blank spaces on the map of Asia [1, 24].

The term “Tartary,” or Tartaria, entered the European lexicon in the 13th century following the Mongol invasions [9]. It was an exonym, a name applied by outsiders, derived from the “Tatars,” a generalized term for the various Mongol and Turkic peoples of the Eurasian Steppe [1, 9]. European writers and mapmakers frequently added an extra ‘r’ to the name, conflating it with Tartarus, the underworld of torment from Greek mythology, a linguistic quirk that betrayed the fear and apprehension the Mongol conquests had instilled in Europe [1, 9]. For centuries, “Tartary” served as a convenient, if profoundly imprecise, label for the vast, enigmatic expanse of North and Central Asia that lay beyond the direct knowledge of the Western world [1, 24]. It was, as described by the Library of Congress, a “cognitive placeholder for complexity, diversity, and scale,” a way to give a name to a region whose true ethnic, political, and geographical diversity was not yet understood [1].

The cartographic record from before 1750 vividly illustrates this state of limited knowledge. Early modern maps, such as the one featured in Abraham Ortelius’s groundbreaking 1570 atlas, *Theatrum Orbis Terrarum*, depicted Tartary as a single, sprawling territory [1, 2]. The map, titled *Tartaria siue magni chami imperivm* (“Tartaria or the kingdom of the great Cham”), was an anachronistic representation of the historical Mongol Empire, which had fragmented centuries earlier [1, 2, 12]. It showed a unified kingdom stretching from the Volga River to the Pacific Ocean, ruled by a “great Cham” or Khan. The geography was speculative, blending Marco Polo’s accounts with myth and rumor [2]. It featured the supposed location of the ancient Mongol capital, Karakum, but also omitted major geographical features like the Korean and Kamchatka peninsulas, while placing North America just across a narrow, non-existent “Strait of Anian” [1, 2]. Later 17th-century maps by cartographers like Gerard Mercator, Jodocus Hondius, and Willem & Joan Blaeu continued this tradition, depicting a vast “Tartar Empire” and incorporating mythical elements, such as devils in the Lop Desert, alongside real features like the Great Wall of China [5, 6, 7]. These maps presented Tartary not as a contemporary political state but as a historical and geographical concept, a label for lands inhabited by a variety of peoples rather than a unified polity [1].

The mid-18th century marked a crucial turning point in the cartography of Asia [1, 9]. The monolithic “Tartary” of earlier maps began to fracture into more specific, politically informed regions [1, 9, 24]. This transformation was a direct result of increased exploration and, most significantly, the eastward expansion of the Russian Empire and the consolidation of power by the Qing Dynasty in China [1, 9]. As more reliable data from missionaries, diplomats, and military surveyors became available, mapmakers began to subdivide the vast territory. The work of the French cartographer Guillaume de L’Isle was pioneering in this respect. His *Carte de Tartarie* (c. 1706) was one of the first to systematically delineate multiple Tartaries, including “Muscovite or Russian Tartary” for the lands being absorbed by Russia, “Chinese Tartary” for regions under Qing influence like Manchuria and Mongolia, and “Independent Tartary” for the khanates of Central Asia not yet under direct European or Chinese control [1, 8, 9, 22]. Other designations, such as “Little Tartary” for the Crimean Khanate, also became common [1, 9]. This subdivision represented a significant increase in geographical knowledge, moving from a single vague label to a more nuanced, albeit still Eurocentric, understanding of the region’s complex political landscape.

The ultimate disappearance of “Tartary” from maps by the late 19th century was the logical conclusion of this process [1, 9]. The primary driver was the relentless expansion and administrative consolidation of the Russian Empire [1, 9, 24]. As Russia conquered and colonized North and Central Asia, the term “Muscovite Tartary” was officially and universally replaced by “Siberia,” a name derived from the Siberian Khanate, one of the first major conquests east of the Urals [1, 9]. The region was no longer a vaguely defined part of “Tartary” but a collection of specific Russian governorates like Tobolsk and Yakutsk, with surveyed and demarcated boundaries. Simultaneously, the 19th-century strategic rivalry between the British and Russian Empires in Central Asia, known as the “Great Game,” spurred intensive mapping efforts for military and political purposes [33, 34]. The ambiguous “Independent Tartary”

was replaced on maps with the names of the specific political entities of the region, such as the khanates of Khiva, Bukhara, and Kokand, or the broader geographical term “Turkestan” [20, 33]. The rise of scientific geography, championed by explorers like Alexander von Humboldt, also contributed by introducing more rigorous, non-historical terms like “Central Asia” [9]. By 1885, maps of Asia showed no “Tartary”; the placeholder had been entirely replaced by the reality of known political and geographical names [1]. This was not an act of suppression but a natural evolution reflecting an increase in knowledge [11].

While European maps were evolving, the vast region they labeled “Tartary” was home to complex societies with their own distinct systems of governance and trade. The dominant political structure was the khanate, a semi-centralized monarchy rooted in tribal confederations and military prowess [74]. These were not provinces of a single “Tartarian Empire” but were independent, often competing states. Legitimacy was frequently tied to the Chinggisid principle, which held that only direct descendants of Genghis Khan could hold the title of supreme khan [73]. However, the lack of a clear rule of primogeniture often led to intense succession struggles, with new leaders typically being elected by a council of tribal chiefs known as a kurultai [73]. The administration within these khanates was often flexible and dualistic; nomadic populations followed traditional customary laws like the Yassa of Genghis Khan, while conquered sedentary populations were often allowed to retain their own legal systems, such as Islamic Sharia law, as long as they paid tribute and remained loyal [76]. This administrative model allowed for the governance of diverse peoples but worked against the formation of a single, monolithic imperial state.

The economy of this region was deeply integrated into broader Eurasian trade networks. Beyond the famed Silk Road, a vital “northern fur road” ran through the Siberian taiga [78, 79]. This trade was centered on “soft gold”—the highly prized furs of animals like sable, ermine, and black fox [79, 81]. A single prime sable pelt could be immensely valuable, and the demand for these furs in China, Persia, and Europe was a major economic driver. This “fur fever” was the primary impetus for Russia’s expansion into Siberia [79]. The Russian state established a system of tribute known as *yasak*, which required indigenous Siberian peoples to pay an annual tax in furs [79]. This system not only generated enormous revenue for the tsarist treasury, at one point accounting for over 10% of the state’s income, but also drove the administrative and military consolidation of Siberia, directly contributing to the replacement of “Muscovite Tartary” with “Siberia” on European maps [79].

A pivotal event that occurred during this era of Russian expansion and geopolitical transformation was Napoleon’s invasion of Russia in 1812 [62]. The campaign culminated in the French occupation of Moscow and the subsequent fire that consumed the city. When Napoleon’s Grande Armée entered Moscow on September 14, 1812, they found a city largely abandoned by its 270,000 inhabitants, an exodus orchestrated by the city’s governor, Count Fyodor Rostopchin [37, 41, 43]. Fires broke out almost immediately and, fanned by strong winds, quickly grew into a massive conflagration that raged for five days [37]. The city, built predominantly of wood, became a firestorm. The destruction was immense, with an estimated three-quarters of the city, including over 6,000 residential buildings, being destroyed [37]. The dominant historical view is that the fire was a deliberate act of scorched-earth warfare masterminded by Rostopchin, who had also ordered the removal or destruction of all firefighting equipment [36, 37, 43, 44]. This act of “extraordinary resolution,” as Napoleon himself reportedly called it, denied the French army shelter and supplies, turning their strategic victory into a logistical nightmare [38]. After a fruitless five-week wait for Tsar Alexander I to surrender, Napoleon was forced to begin his catastrophic winter retreat [62]. The fire of Moscow was thus a critical turning point, demonstrating the Russian state’s willingness to make immense sacrifices to defend its sovereignty and setting the stage for the utter destruction of the Grande Armée. This event underscores the formidable power and strategic depth of the very empire that was, at the same time, absorbing and renaming the lands of “Tartary.”

Critical Analysis of Alternative Theories

In recent decades, the historical term “Tartary” has been co-opted by a sprawling pseudohistorical conspiracy theory [10, 90]. This narrative posits the existence of a global, technologically advanced “Tartarian Empire” that was deliberately destroyed and erased from history in the 19th century. Proponents of this theory reinterpret historical maps, architecture, and geological features as evidence for this lost civilization. A critical analysis of these claims, when compared with the documented historical and scientific record, reveals a pattern of misinterpretation, speculation, and a disregard for verifiable evidence.

The “Lost Advanced Civilization” and “Ether Energy”

The core tenet of the Tartarian theory is that it was a worldwide empire possessing technology far beyond its time, including the harnessing of “ether energy” or atmospheric free energy [91]. This energy was supposedly collected and distributed by ornate antennas and domes on buildings that are now misinterpreted as mere architectural features. Proponents point to the intricate metalwork and grand scale of 19th-century Beaux-Arts and classical revival buildings found across the globe as relics of this advanced civilization. However, this claim is entirely speculative and lacks any form of credible support. There is no archaeological evidence—no artifacts, no power plants, no technological remnants—to substantiate the existence of such advanced technology [92]. The architectural styles cited as “Tartarian” are well-documented historical movements with known architects, construction records, and established lineages tracing back to classical Greek and Roman designs [86]. The theory ignores the entire history of architecture and engineering, replacing it with a fantasy of lost technology for which no proof exists.

Systematic Historical Erasure and the “Mud Flood”

A central pillar of the conspiracy is the belief that the Tartarian Empire was destroyed by a cataclysmic “mud flood” in the 19th century, and that a global cabal subsequently conspired to erase all knowledge of it from history [32, 90]. The primary “evidence” for this mud flood is the observation that many old buildings have windows and doors that are now partially buried below street level [32, 86]. This phenomenon, however, is a well-understood aspect of urban development. Over decades and centuries, street levels in cities naturally rise as new layers of pavement are laid, infrastructure like pipes and cables are installed, and debris from construction and demolition accumulates [86]. What appears to be a buried ground floor is often simply the result of the surrounding street level having risen over time. The claim of a coordinated, worldwide effort to erase an entire global empire from all historical records, maps, and memory is equally untenable. It would have required a conspiracy of unimaginable scale and perfection, involving thousands of historians, librarians, cartographers, and officials across competing nations, all without leaving a single piece of direct evidence of their plot. The documented evolution of the term “Tartary” on maps, from a vague placeholder to specific regional names, is presented by the theory as an act of erasure. In reality, it represents an increase in knowledge, not its suppression [1, 11].

Anomalous Characteristics of the 1812 Moscow Fires

Some proponents of the Tartarian theory incorporate the 1812 Fire of Moscow into their narrative, suggesting it was not a conventional fire but an “anomalous” event, perhaps a targeted attack using advanced weaponry to destroy a Tartarian stronghold. They point to the fire’s immense scale and intensity as proof that it could not have been a normal conflagration. This interpretation ignores the wealth of historical and eyewitness accounts that provide a clear and conventional explanation for the disaster [37, 38]. Moscow in 1812 was a city built largely of wood, providing a massive and continuous fuel load [37]. Historical records confirm that strong winds were present, creating the perfect condi-

tions for a firestorm, a phenomenon where a large fire generates its own wind system, drastically accelerating its spread [37]. Most critically, the city's military governor, Count Rostopchin, had deliberately ordered the removal or sabotage of all firefighting equipment, including pumps and engines [37, 43]. The combination of abundant fuel, high winds, and a complete lack of any suppression capability is a well-understood formula for a catastrophic urban fire. Eyewitness accounts from both French and Russian sources describe the capture of Russian arsonists who confessed to acting on orders [37, 38]. The fire's intensity was not anomalous; it was the predictable and intended result of a brutal act of scorched-earth warfare.

Circular Formations as Evidence of Advanced Technology

The landscape of western Russia, across which Napoleon's army marched, is dotted with numerous circular lakes and depressions. The Tartarian theory speculatively reinterprets these natural geological features as the remnants of advanced technology, such as energy plants, weapon emplacements, or the craters left by an advanced war that destroyed the empire. This claim is directly contradicted by established geological science. The vast majority of the small, circular lakes in this region, particularly in areas like the Smolensk Oblast, are classic examples of **kettle lakes** [48, 49, 52]. These are common glacial landforms created at the end of the last Ice Age when large blocks of ice detached from retreating glaciers, were buried by sediment, and then slowly melted, causing the ground above to collapse into a depression [52]. Their circular shape is a natural result of the melting process. Larger, more ancient circular features found in Russia, such as the 80-km-wide Puchezh-Katunki structure, are confirmed **impact craters** or astroblemes, the heavily eroded scars left by meteorite collisions millions of years ago [55, 67]. There is no scientific evidence to suggest these formations are artificial or the result of unknown forces. They are a natural and well-documented part of the Earth's geological history.

Theories on the Great Wall's Origin

In a complete reversal of the historical record, a key claim within the Tartarian narrative is that the Great Wall of China was not built by the Chinese to defend against northern nomads. Instead, it is proposed that the wall was built by the "Tartarians" to defend their empire from the Chinese to the south [85, 90]. To support this, proponents falsely claim that the wall's defensive features, such as crenellations and loopholes, face south. This assertion is demonstrably false [83, 85]. Physical inspection of the wall, along with countless architectural and historical studies, confirms that its defensive orientation is unequivocally northward [83]. The wall was a massive, multi-generational project undertaken by various Chinese dynasties, most notably the Ming Dynasty, for the explicit purpose of protecting their agrarian civilization from raids and invasions by the nomadic peoples of the steppe—the very people Europeans labeled "Tartars" [82, 85]. The wall's watchtowers, fortresses, and battlements were all designed for observation of and defense against threats from the north. The theory of a "Tartarian" wall is a foundational element of the conspiracy that is directly refuted by overwhelming physical and textual evidence.

Alleged Conspiracies Involving Napoleon and Tsar Alexander I

The broader conspiracy narrative often recasts major historical figures and events to fit its story. The 1812 invasion of Russia is sometimes framed not as a conflict between France and Russia, but as a covert joint operation between Napoleon and Tsar Alexander I to destroy the last vestiges of the Tartarian Empire. This speculative claim lacks any basis in the historical record [62]. The 1812 campaign is one of the most intensely studied events in military history, with vast archives of diplomatic correspondence, military orders, and personal memoirs from all sides. None of this evidence suggests a secret alliance or a hidden motive. The war was the culmination of years of escalating political and economic tensions between France and Russia, primarily over Russia's withdrawal from Napoleon's

Continental System against Great Britain [62]. The narrative of a secret pact to destroy Tartary is a modern invention, an attempt to weave a complex historical event into a simplistic conspiratorial framework without any supporting documentation.

Evidence Assessment

To provide clarity, this section assesses the major claims related to Great Tartary, categorizing them based on the strength and nature of the supporting evidence as presented in the synthesized research.

Claim: “Tartary” was a European exonym and cartographic placeholder for a vast, poorly understood region of Asia inhabited by diverse Mongol and Turkic peoples.

* **Assessment:** Supported by historical evidence.

* **Reasoning:** Extensive cartographic analysis from institutions like the Library of Congress and academic sources confirms that “Tartary” was a label used by Western mapmakers, not a self-identified political entity. The term’s origin, its association with the “Tatars,” and its vague, shifting boundaries on maps from the 13th to 18th centuries all point to its function as a label for a region beyond Europe’s direct knowledge [1, 9].

Claim: The disappearance of “Tartary” from maps was a natural evolution driven by increased geographical knowledge and imperial consolidation, particularly by the Russian Empire.

* **Assessment:** Supported by historical evidence.

* **Reasoning:** The historical record clearly documents the Russian expansion across Siberia and into Central Asia. This process involved surveying, administrative organization, and the official replacement of the term “Muscovite Tartary” with “Siberia.” The “Great Game” between Britain and Russia similarly led to the detailed mapping and renaming of “Independent Tartary.” The rise of scientific geography provided a new, more accurate lexicon. This progression represents an increase in knowledge, not a suppression of it [1, 9, 33, 34].

Claim: The peoples of the region labeled “Tartary” were organized into distinct, often competing khanates, not a single, unified empire.

* **Assessment:** Supported by historical evidence.

* **Reasoning:** Historical scholarship on the Mongol successor states and the peoples of the Eurasian Steppe details the political structure of the khanate. The histories of the Golden Horde, the Chagatai Khanate, the Siberian Khanate, and others show they were separate political entities with their own rulers, conflicts, and histories. The concept of a single, overarching “Tartarian Empire” during the early modern period is an anachronism [74, 76].

Claim: The 1812 Fire of Moscow was a deliberate act of scorched-earth warfare orchestrated by Russian authorities.

* **Assessment:** Plausible and widely supported, but not unequivocally proven.

* **Reasoning:** The dominant historical view, supported by strong circumstantial evidence (evacuation of the city, removal of fire equipment) and multiple eyewitness accounts of arson, points to a planned act by Count Rostopchin [37, 43, 44]. However, Rostopchin later denied his role, and alternative explanations, such as Leo Tolstoy’s theory of accidental fires becoming uncontrollable in an abandoned wooden city, exist [37]. While the evidence for a deliberate plan is compelling, the existence of counter-narratives and the impossibility of absolute proof make this a highly plausible and strongly supported theory rather than an undisputed fact.

Claim: The Great Tartarian Empire was a technologically advanced global civilization that was erased from history.

* **Assessment: Purely speculative and contradicts mainstream scholarship.**

* **Reasoning:** There is a complete lack of primary-source evidence—archaeological, textual, or otherwise—to support the existence of this empire. The theory is a modern construct that relies on reinterpreting existing evidence in a way that is inconsistent with established historical and scientific methodology [10, 92].

Claim: Ornate 19th-century architecture and a “mud flood” are evidence of the Tartarian Empire’s destruction.

* **Assessment: Contradicts mainstream scholarship.**

* **Reasoning:** The architectural styles cited as “Tartarian” are well-documented historical movements (e.g., Beaux-Arts, Neoclassicism). The “mud flood” phenomenon is explained by the natural rising of street levels in urban environments over centuries, a process documented by urban archaeologists and historians. The claim ignores these conventional, evidence-based explanations [86].

Claim: Circular geological formations in Russia are evidence of Tartarian advanced technology or warfare.

* **Assessment: Contradicts mainstream scholarship.**

* **Reasoning:** Geological science provides clear and well-documented explanations for these features. The smaller circular lakes are identified as kettle lakes, a product of glaciation. Larger, ancient circular features are identified as meteorite impact craters. These explanations are supported by extensive geological fieldwork and analysis. The “advanced technology” claim is purely speculative [49, 52, 67].

Claim: The Great Wall of China was built by Tartarians with its defenses facing south.

* **Assessment: Contradicts mainstream scholarship and physical evidence.**

* **Reasoning:** Overwhelming historical, archaeological, and architectural evidence confirms the wall was built by Chinese dynasties as a defense against northern invaders. The physical structure of the wall, with its crenellations, watchtowers, and fortresses, is demonstrably oriented northward. The claim is a direct reversal of the factual record [82, 83, 85].

Conclusions

The investigation into Great Tartary reveals a stark dichotomy between a verifiable historical entity and a modern alternative history theory. The research confirms that Tartary, as a historical concept, was a real and significant feature of European consciousness and cartography for over five hundred years. It was a Eurocentric exonym, a label of convenience for the vast and diverse territories of North and Central Asia that were, for much of that period, a terra incognita to the West [1, 9]. The story of Tartary on maps is the story of the gradual and incremental progress of geographical knowledge [1, 24]. Its initial depiction as a monolithic, semi-mythical empire gave way to a more nuanced, subdivided representation as exploration and imperial expansion provided more accurate data. Its eventual disappearance was not a sinister erasure but a logical and necessary step in the advancement of cartographic science, as the vague placeholder was replaced by the precise political and geographical realities of Siberia, Turkestan, Mongolia, and Manchuria [1, 11].

The historical reality of the peoples who lived in the lands labeled Tartary is one of complex political organization in the form of khanates, dynamic tribal confederations, and deep integration into continental trade networks like the Fur Road [74, 79]. These societies were not part of a single, unified empire but were a mosaic of distinct cultures and polities whose histories were shaped by the harsh environment of the steppe and their interactions with neighboring sedentary civilizations in China, Persia, and Russia. The Russian Empire’s expansion eastward, driven by the lucrative fur trade and geopolitical ambition, was the primary force that ultimately absorbed and renamed these territories, cementing the transition from “Tartary” to “Siberia” in the world’s atlases [9, 79].

In stark contrast, Tartary as an alternative history theory is a modern myth [10, 90]. The narrative of a lost, technologically advanced global empire destroyed by a cataclysm and erased by a conspiracy is a product of speculation, built upon the misinterpretation of historical maps, a misunderstanding of urban development and geological processes, and a rejection of established historical and scientific evidence [11, 49, 86]. The theory mistakes a cartographic convention for a political reality, architectural history for lost technology, and natural landforms for evidence of ancient warfare. While it provides a seductive narrative of a hidden, glorious past, it is a narrative that is fundamentally unsupported by the standards of scholarly inquiry.

In conclusion, the research reveals two Tartaries. One is a fascinating chapter in the history of geography, reflecting Europe's changing perception of Asia. The other is a pseudohistorical invention. A balanced understanding requires acknowledging the rich and complex history of the actual peoples of the Eurasian Steppe while simultaneously recognizing that the "Tartarian Empire" of modern conspiracy is a fiction, a phantom empire built not on evidence, but on the romantic and conspiratorial reimagining of the past [1, 10, 74, 90].

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